

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Name what you need -> Not what they did wrong -> Invite the alternative

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

State your boundary as a need you have, not as a complaint about what they did. One sentence. Then stop.

BEST FOR

- Setting work limits without creating conflict
- Declining requests without damaging relationships
- Naming a personal boundary in a close relationship
- Saying no to something unreasonable without escalating

PHRASE BANK

Boundary Statements · As a need, not a complaint

- "I am not able to take that on right now."
- "I need to keep that part of my work separate."
- "I am not comfortable with that — here is what I can do instead."
- "That is not something I am willing to agree to."
- "I need to be honest: I cannot do that and do it well."
- "That does not work for me. What would work is..."
- "I want to say no to that clearly, not passively."
- "I cannot commit to that deadline — I can commit to X."

Alternatives · Offering a different path

- "What I can offer instead is..."
- "Here is what I am able to do..."
- "An alternative that might work: ..."
- "What I need in order to do this is..."
- "The version I could commit to is..."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Passive: 'I am quite busy... I will try... I will see...'
Better: I am not sure I can do that.
Best: I cannot take that on. What I can do is X.
- Weak: Blaming: 'You always ask me last minute'
Better: Short notice requests are difficult for me.
Best: I need more lead time for this. I can commit to X if you can give me Y days.
- Weak: Over-apologising: 'I am so sorry, I really wish I could...'
Better: I am sorry — I cannot do it.
Best: I cannot do it. Here is what I can offer instead.

DECISION TREE

If Someone is making a request that crosses a limit

Name the limit as a need. Offer an alternative if one exists.

"I am not able to take that on. I can do X instead."

If You feel guilt about saying no

Separate the guilt from the boundary. The boundary can still be right.

"I know this is not what you need to hear — and I still need to say no."

If They push back on your boundary

Hold it without escalating.

"I understand that creates difficulty. My answer is still no."

If The boundary is personal and feels vulnerable to state

Name it plainly. The vulnerability is not the same as the boundary being wrong.

"This is not something I am comfortable with, and I want to be honest about that."

If You are over-explaining your no

Stop. The boundary does not need a detailed justification.

"The answer is no — I do not need to explain the full reason."

SCENARIOS

Being asked to take on work you cannot handle

Name the limit plainly. Offer a different scope if possible. — "I am not able to take this on at the current quality level. I could do a smaller version by X."

Being pushed for a commitment you are not ready to give

Name what you can commit to — not what you cannot. — "I cannot commit to that timeline. I can commit to having something to you by X."

A personal boundary being crossed in a close relationship

Name it as a need, not as a complaint about them. — "I need some time to myself after work before I can be present. It is not about you."

Being asked to do something that conflicts with your values

Be direct. You do not have to justify the values. — "That is not something I am willing to do — I need to be clear about that."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the behaviour is so serious that a firm objection — not a politely framed boundary — is the right response.
- In safety-critical situations requiring immediate compliance rather than a collaborative conversation.
- In significant power imbalances where a boundary will be ignored or punished — escalation through other channels may be needed.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the limits

Identify one thing you have been saying yes to that you should say no to. Do not act yet.

Day 2 — As a need, not a complaint

Practice stating a limit as 'I need X' rather than 'You did Y.'

Day 3 — The clean no

Say no to one small request today without over-explaining or apologising excessively.

Day 4 — Offer an alternative

When you say no, offer one specific alternative rather than leaving a void.

Day 5 — Hold the boundary when pushed

If your boundary is challenged, hold it calmly without escalating.

Day 6 — Medium-stakes boundary

State one genuine limit in a work or personal context where it matters.

Day 7 — Calibration

Were your limits respected? Did any boundary feel like blame? Did you hold them when tested?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the limit as a need — not as a complaint about them?

- Did I keep the boundary statement short and clear?
- Did I offer an alternative where one genuinely existed?
- Did I avoid over-apologising or over-explaining?
- Did I hold the boundary when it was tested?
- Did I state the limit without passive aggression or sarcasm?
- Did the relationship stay intact after I set the boundary?
- Did I follow through on what I said I would not do?